SESSION 3

Stakeholder Mapping + Causal Loop Introduction

Design Thinking for MBAs (Hybrid Section)

Thursday, March 12, 2026 | 6:30 PM | Online (Zoom) | Faculty: Patrick Ray

Check-In

Quick round: Has anything shifted in your thinking since Session 2?

What did writing about your observation experience surface?

5 minutes

Find the Duct Tape

What did you find this week? Any workarounds, improvised fixes, duct tape solutions?

Drop yours in the chat in one sentence. Then we'll hear 2-3 people elaborate.

10 minutes

- What's the fix? What's the **real problem underneath**?
- These workarounds are exactly what you'll look for during stakeholder research
- People's improvised fixes tell you where the system is failing

Tonight's Arc

Two breakout room cycles, two tools:

Stakeholder Mapping

- Deepen your Session 2 stakeholder list
- Map optimization goals, constraints, concerns
- Include at least one **extreme user**

Causal Loop Mapping

- Learn a tool for mapping system dynamics
- Draft an initial causal loop for your scenario
- Identify what your research needs to test

Design Abilities Tonight

Learn From Others

Empathize with diverse viewpoints. Observe and learn from unfamiliar contexts. Tonight: stakeholder mapping, extreme users, seeking perspectives you wouldn't naturally encounter.

Synthesize Information

Make sense of information and find insight within. Tonight: causal loop mapping turns scattered observations into a system-level picture.

Navigate Ambiguity

Persist in the discomfort of not knowing. Tonight: your maps are hypotheses, not answers. The research period starts with uncertainty.

Move Between Concrete and Abstract

Zoom in on specific stakeholder concerns, zoom out to system dynamics. Tonight: you'll do both, repeatedly.

Why Map Stakeholders?

A stakeholder map makes differences visible: who's affected, what they want, and where their interests conflict.

What You're Looking For

- Who is **affected** by this problem?
- Who has **influence** over it?
- Where do their interests conflict?
- Who is **invisible** in the current system?

Why It Matters for Design

- Solutions that work for one stakeholder often create problems for another
- The stakeholders you forget are usually the ones whose needs go unmet
- Your research plan depends on knowing **who to talk to** and **what to ask them**

Stakeholder Mapping

Breakout rooms by team. Deepen your stakeholder list from Session 2. Identify 4-5 stakeholders for your scenario.

For each stakeholder, fill in the template on the next slide:

Include at least one **extreme user**: someone who experiences the problem most intensely.

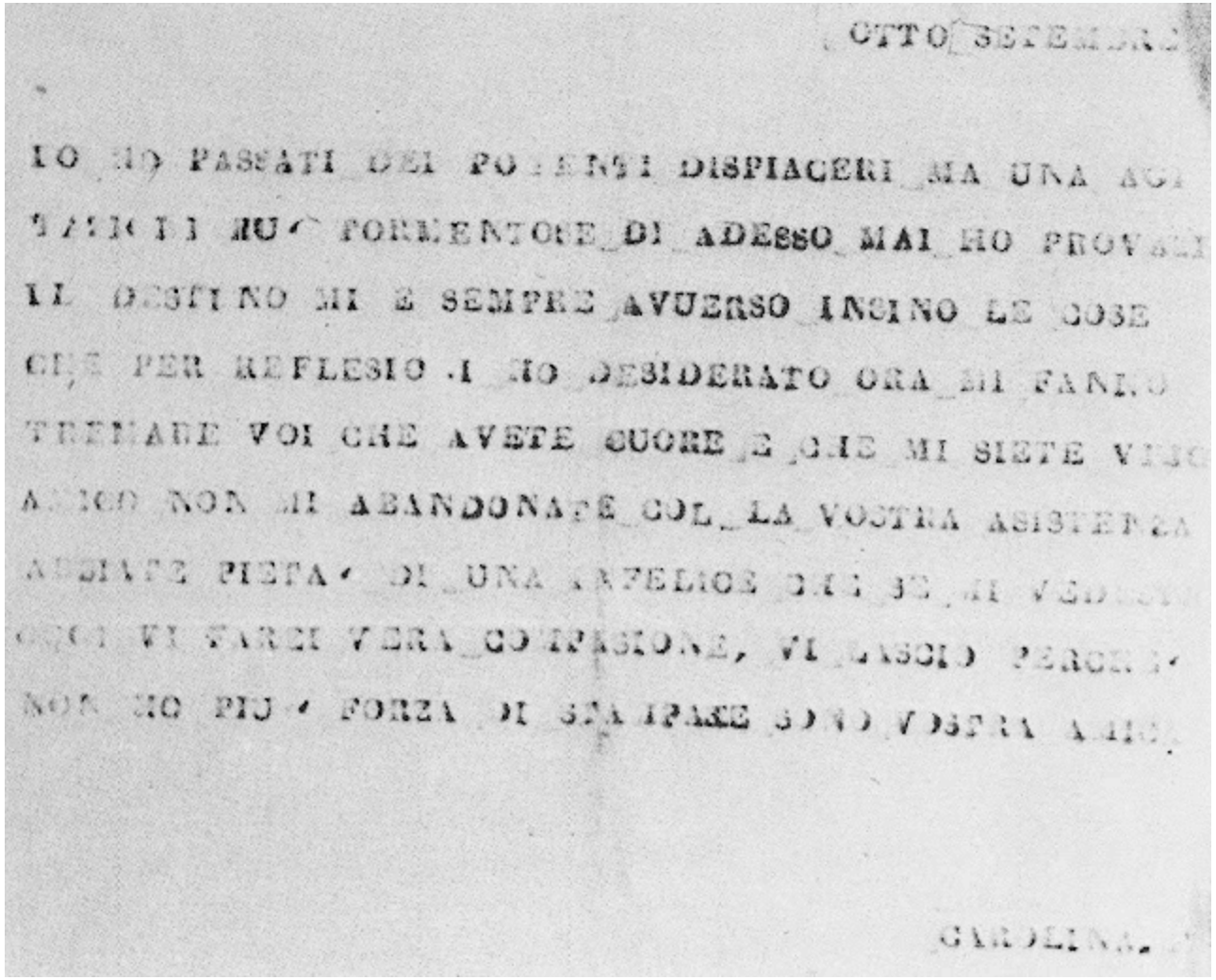
20 minutes

Stakeholder Template

Element	Prompt
Who	Specific role or identity (not generic)
Optimizes for	What are they trying to maximize?
Constraints	What limits their options?
Top concerns	What do they care about most? (2-3)
Access	Which team member can reach this person?

> If everyone on your list wants the same thing, you're missing someone. Stakeholder maps without tension are incomplete.

What Is This?



OTTO SETEMBRE

IO HO PASSATI DEI POCHI DISPIACERI MA UNA AGI
TAZIONE MU FORMENTOSE DI ADESSO MAI HO PROVATI
IL DESTINO MI E SEMPRE AVVERSO INCINO LE COSE
CHE PER REFLESIONE HO DESIDERATO ORA MI FANNO
TREMARE VOI CHE AVETE CUORE E CHE MI SIETE VICI
ANCO NON MI ABBANDONATE COL LA VOSTRA ASISTENZA
ABBIATE PIETA DI UNA INFELICE CHE SE MI VEDESTI
OGGI VI FARESTI VERA COMPASIONE, VI BACIO PERCHE
NON HO PIU FORZA DI STAMPARE SONO VOSTRA AMICA

GARDELINA.

The First Typewriter

This is one of the oldest typewritten documents in existence. Written in 1808.

The machine that produced it didn't survive. **But the letters did.**

In 1808, Italian inventor Pellegrino Turri built one of the first working typewriters. He built it for exactly one person: **Countess Carolina Fantoni, who was blind.** She wanted to write letters independently, without dictating to someone else.

Extreme Users Drive Innovation

Turri didn't set out to invent the typewriter. He set out to solve one person's problem: a blind woman who wanted to write her own letters.

That's what **extreme users** do. Their needs are so acute that they force you past incremental fixes into fundamentally different solutions.

Debrief: The Overlooked Stakeholder

Each team shares one stakeholder they almost forgot or didn't initially consider.

- Why do we overlook certain stakeholders? What makes some **invisible**?
- The stakeholders you overlook are usually the ones absorbing the cost of the current system.

10 minutes

Causal Loop Mapping

Why does this problem persist?

What Is a Causal Loop Map?

A diagram that shows the **system dynamics** underlying your problem: what causes what, what reinforces what, and why it doesn't just fix itself.

The Building Blocks

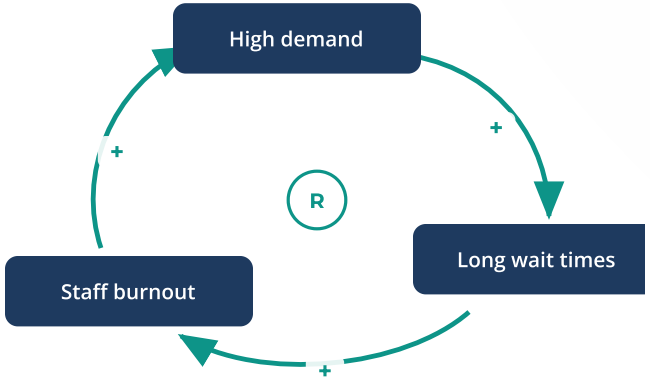
- **Nodes**: Specific factors in the system
- **Arrows**: Direction of influence
- **+/- signs**: (+) as A increases, B increases. (-) as A increases, B decreases.

Two Types of Loops

- **Reinforcing (R)**: Self-amplifying. The problem feeds itself.
- **Balancing (B)**: Self-correcting. Something pushes back.

Reading a Causal Loop

A simple three-node reinforcing loop:



How to Read It

1. **Follow the arrows.** High demand → long wait times → staff burnout → high demand
2. **Check the signs.** All (+) means each factor increases the next
3. **Identify the loop type.** All same direction? Reinforcing (R): it spirals. A minus sign flips the direction? **Balancing (B)**: something pushes back.

From Observation to Causal Loop

We'll review a real TETHER observation, then walk through the causal loop map it produced.

Four loops to trace:

1. **R1** "Invisibility Cycle": The core reinforcing loop. The problem feeds itself.
2. **B1** "Companion Workaround": A balancing loop. Does this solve the problem?
3. **B2** "Accidental Aid": Two workarounds converge on the same variable.
4. **R2** "Crowd Amplifier": A second reinforcing pathway. It gets worse.

As we trace, watch for: Where does an **effect become a cause**? Who **benefits**? Who **bears the cost**?

The Observation

99 Ranch Food Court, Houston

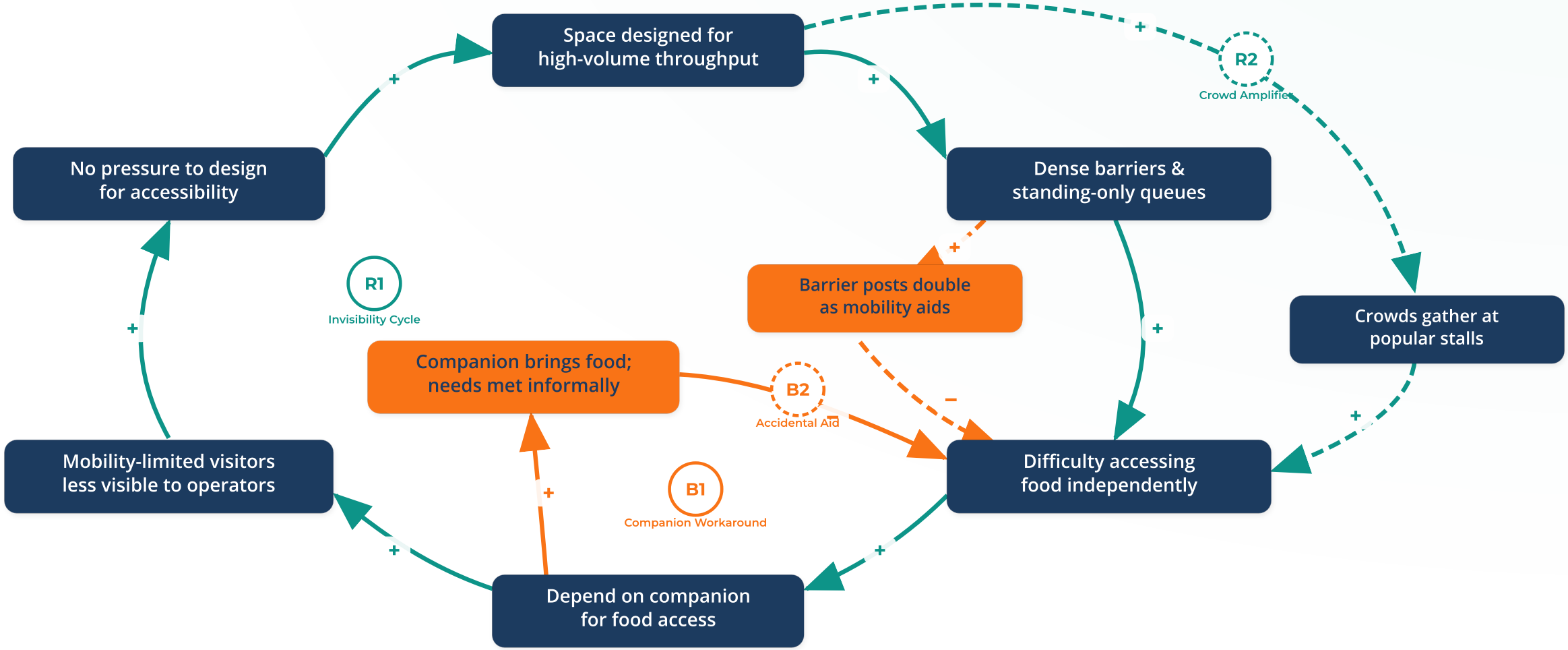
An elderly man with an unsteady gait and a tall cane enters the food court. He steadies himself on retractable barrier posts spaced one foot apart. There is no break in the perimeter barrier. He sits alone at a four-top with no food. A younger companion joins him and shares food. Meanwhile, up to 20 people crowd around the duck stall's hot case.

What do you notice?

- Who is this space designed for?
- What workarounds are happening?
- Who benefits from the current design?
- Who bears the cost?

Causal Loop Example

— Reinforcing (R1, R2) — Balancing (B1, B2) (+) same direction (−) opposite direction



Causal Loop Drafting

Sketch an initial causal loop map for your scenario.

1. Put your **core problem** in the center. Be specific.
2. Identify **4-5 contributing factors and effects**. Draw the arrows.
3. Find at least **one loop**. Label it R or B.
4. Add **+/- signs** to your arrows.
5. Ask: **who benefits** from this staying the way it is?

20 minutes

What a Good Causal Loop Looks Like

Common Pitfalls

- Nodes too abstract ("bad communication")
- All arrows going one direction (that's a chain, not a loop)
- Forgetting to close the loop
- Symptoms instead of causes

Signs You're On Track

- You can trace a path that **returns to where it started**
- Your +/- signs make logical sense
- You found something that surprised you
- You can name who benefits from the status quo

> Not "communication issues." What specifically? "Frontline staff feedback doesn't reach decision-makers." Now you can map what causes that and trace the loop.

Share Your Loops

Each team: **"Our reinforcing loop is ___. Our balancing loop is ___."**

- Does it ring true? What would you want to investigate to test it?
- **Where would you intervene?** Which node, if changed, would break the cycle?
- Name your loops. A loop with a name is a loop your team can reference.

What's Due for Session 4

Thursday, March 26

Stakeholder Research

Team deliverable. Each member conducts 1-2 observations or interviews, then compile.

Details on Canvas.

Causal Loop Map

Team deliverable. Start from tonight's draft. Let your research reveal new dynamics.

Details on Canvas.

What's Next

- **Session 4**: Thursday, March 26, 6:30 PM (Online, Zoom)
- Synthesize research, refine causal loop maps, define the problem

> Both deliverables are hypotheses right now. The next two weeks of research will tell you where you're wrong. That's the point.